

Auwa Manifesto

A reminder for Tom & Rieko, from Tom & Rieko. For when it's late, the code won't compile, and you've forgotten why you started.

The Short Version

Rieko spent ten years creating a universe about a cosmic being who reveals the soul within all living things. Tom has spent twenty years building products and getting other people's ideas into the world. Now it's your turn. Auwa is yours: your philosophy, your art, your vision. The world doesn't have anything like it, and the tools to build it finally exist. The downside is tiny. The upside is open-ended. And the process itself, making something beautiful together, learning new tools, getting creative again, is the point, regardless of outcome.

And you're not starting from nothing. You're starting with more relevant experience than almost anyone else who could attempt this.

The Nine Reasons

1. Rieko's dream, realised.

Ten years of illustrated stories sitting in a drawer. A series of complete narratives about a being who reveals the Kokoro in flowers, coral, tanuki, and humans. A philosophy of interconnectedness that Rieko grew up with in Kansai, embedded into every page. The original plan was printed books. The pivot to a digital universe (app, social, figures, stories released over time) is bigger and better. This is the release Rieko's work has been waiting for. Not a compromise. An evolution.

2. Making something that actually matters.

Not another corporate website. Not another brand refresh for a company that won't exist in five years. Auwa helps people notice how they feel, name it precisely, and see their patterns over time. That's emotional intelligence. That's the skill the entire world is waking up to as AI handles

everything else. If Auwa helps even a few hundred people become more aware of themselves, the people around them, and the natural world, that's a contribution worth making. And it spreads Japanese philosophy globally in the most authentic way possible: through lived experience, not a textbook.

3. Getting creative again.

Years of client work. Years of executing other people's briefs to other people's standards with other people's timelines. Auwa is a return to why you both became designers in the first place, to make beautiful things that mean something. Generating wild visual concepts in MidJourney, designing an ambient emotional experience, creating poetic AI reflections, illustrating characters, composing audio, and shipping something into the world with your names on it. That's not work. That's the reason you chose this career.

4. A new revenue stream (if it works).

More Air has been the sole income for 17 years. AI is changing the design industry fast. Having a product generating recurring subscription revenue, figure sales, and potential B2B licensing is genuine diversification. Even modest Auwa revenue (£30-50k/year from app + figures) changes the dynamic. No longer entirely dependent on the next client saying yes.

5. AI-native fluency (the hidden asset).

After the build sprint, firsthand experience with Claude Code, Cursor, MidJourney, Runway, Suno, vo, Vercel, Sanity, Stripe, and the Claude API. Complete fluency in AI-native design and development. That knowledge makes More Air genuinely AI-native: not "we've experimented with AI" but "we built and shipped a product with it." Different conversation with every future client.

6. The venture-spinning capability.

Once you've done this once, you can do it again. Faster. Better. Auwa teaches the entire process: idea to brand to product to build to launch to iterate. The next digital venture takes weeks, not months. That portfolio model is how small studios build real independence.

7. You've already done this — separately. Now you're doing it together.

Look at what you're each bringing to this:

Rieko: Ten years creating the Auwa universe. A series of complete illustrated stories. Native Japanese speaker who grew up in Kansai with Yaoyorozu no Kami as lived philosophy, not something researched from a book. Decade of Japanese corporate experience (understanding merchant relationships, business culture, communication norms). The ability to call a ceramicist in Arita or a knife-maker in Seki and have a real conversation in their language, on their terms.

Tom: Built and operated a Japanese multi-merchant platform (2005-2007) selling Japanese design objects to Western buyers — the exact same model the Auwa Store will use. Distributed KAWS's first international releases. Designed the Monolise Japanese craftsman store concept. Published photographer whose Japan work has 17M+ views on Unsplash and been used by Condé Nast Traveler, Vogue, WEF, Travel + Leisure, TimeOut, and Culture Trip — from just 7 photos uploaded and left untouched. 15+ years of Japan trips producing a massive content vault. Nokia Animaru: designed a character-based wellness app for Nokia San Francisco — the exact same DNA as Kokoro Mirror. 20+ years at Nokia, Apple, Sky building products at scale.

Separately, each of you has done pieces of this before and succeeded. Auwa is the first time you're combining all of it under one roof. That's not a leap of faith. That's a convergence.

8. Something that's truly yours.

After 17 years of More Air, you've built beautiful things for other people's brands, other people's visions, other people's timelines. Auwa is different. Nobody is approving your colour palette or questioning your creative direction. Every decision is yours. Every beautiful detail exists because you both believed it should. Client work pays the bills. Auwa feeds the soul.

9. A small act of preservation, beyond the personal one. (Added 27 May 2026.)

The Daily Light + Firefly Trove mechanic gives every Auwa user a way to capture small moments of light from their own day that would otherwise have been lost. The fireflies in the app are also a real-world commitment: five percent of every subscription supports firefly habitat conservation in Japan and globally, from the first paid subscriber. Real fireflies are disappearing because the world is too loud, too bright, too polluted; some scientists describe the current cohort as the last generation that will reliably witness them in many regions. Auwa is a small, sustained act of preservation, of one's own small good moments and of a fragile species that matters to Rieko personally. The personal practice and the brand's commitment to the world are the same gesture.

Above All: This One Is Ours

Every reason above is true, but underneath all of them sits the one that matters most, and it is worth saying plainly.

For nearly two decades we have made beautiful things for other people. Other companies' visions, other people's briefs, other people's timelines and standards and approvals. We got very good at it, and it built the security that makes everything else possible. But it was always theirs, not ours. The credit, the ownership, the thing itself, all handed over at the end.

Auwa is the first thing that is entirely ours. Our philosophy, our art, our story, made on our terms and in our time, the two of us combining everything we have learned across two careers into one thing with both our fingerprints on every part of it. Nobody approves the palette. Nobody questions the direction. When it is good, it is good because we decided together that it should be.

This is not only about impact, though the impact is real and it is what drives Rieko most: a philosophy of awareness and interconnectedness, carried from Kansai into a distracted world, helping even a few people feel more, notice more, live more gently. That mission matters enormously. But there is a second thing sitting alongside it, quieter and just as true. We want something we made that we are proud of. Something that, years from now, we can point to and say we built that, the two of us, out of nothing but a decade of Rieko's drawings and everything we knew how to do. Not a career that reads as a sea of other people's logos, but client work plus one thing that was unmistakably ours.

And there is a deeper reason still, the one that does not need dressing up. We could not have children. Four rounds of IVF, and then the quiet work of making peace with a different life than the one we planned. That life is a good one, freely chosen to inhabit, and it is not a wound we carry into every room. But it does mean the things we make together carry a particular weight. Auwa is, in the most honest sense, something we are bringing into the world together and sending out to live beyond us: a universe Rieko imagined and we built, that will hopefully reach people we will never meet, long after we have stopped tending it. That is its own kind of legacy, and it is not a small one.

So when the doubt comes, and it will, remember that the client work was never going to be the thing we look back on. It paid for the life and it sharpened the craft, and that is enough for it to have been worth doing. But Auwa is the thing we get to be proud of, the one with our names on it, the one that is ours.

What Happens If It Really Works

- **Hotel partnerships.** Flying to Kyoto to present Auwa to Hoshinoya. Rieko pitching in Japanese. Walking through a ryokan where guests use a digital awareness experience you designed. Aman Tokyo. Park Hyatt. Six Senses.
- **Japanese craftsman collaborations.** Daruma painters in Gunma, kokeshi makers in Tohoku, ceramic artists in Arita. Rieko building relationships in Japanese. Limited-edition Auwa objects bridging centuries of tradition with modern digital experience.
- **Exhibitions.** "Auwa Revealed" in a London gallery or Tokyo space. Rieko's original illustrations on the walls. A live Kokoro Mirror station. Craftsman demonstrations.
- **Figures that people treasure.** Hand-finished, numbered, signed by Rieko. Never reissued. Each a small piece of the universe she spent a decade creating.
- **Travel.** Japan, regularly. Not as tourists but as creators with purpose: meeting artisans, scouting exhibition spaces, photographing seasonal content in the actual landscapes that inspired the 72 micro-seasons.
- **Press and recognition.** "The couple who spent a decade building a universe in secret and then released it as a Japanese awareness brand." A story Dezeen, Monocle, It's Nice That, and Fast Company would want to tell.
- **The journal.** Atmospheric writing about Japan that builds a quiet authority. Craftsman profiles, seasonal essays, onsen mornings, temple visits. Content that drives people to the brand and makes the store, app, and book feel like parts of a whole.
- **B2B licensing.** Hospitals, corporate wellness, neurodiversity clinics, schools. Meaningful revenue while putting Rieko's philosophy to work where it can make a real difference.

None of this is guaranteed. All of it is possible. And none of it happens unless you build the website first.

What Happens If It's a Slow Burner

The most likely scenario. And it's still good.

Small but genuine user base (50-200 regular users). Few thousand social followers. App runs for £50-80/month. 2-3 hours a week to maintain.

Auwa quietly serves four purposes:

1. **Living portfolio piece.** Hand your phone to a potential client. They type how they feel, the light shower plays, Auwa reveals their Kokoro. In 60 seconds they've experienced AI

integration, brand design, product strategy, animation, and emotional design.

2. **Social content engine on autopilot.** 72 micro-seasons refresh every 5 days. Rieko batch-produces a quarter's content. The accounts post themselves. Slow communities are the ones that last.
3. **A platform ready for its moment.** If awareness enters mainstream conversation, Auwa is already there. Most opportunities are missed because people weren't ready. You'll be ready.
4. **An ongoing creative practice.** Every five days, a new micro-season. Every few months, a new figure or story segment. A reason to keep making meaningful things outside of client work.

Slow burners compound. The content archive grows. Early users' Kokoro Archives deepen. One viral Kokoro card, one press mention, one influencer discovery, and the slow burn catches.

The Worst Case

Nobody uses the app, nobody buys figures, social accounts stagnate.

What you've lost: ~~£2,000-3,000 in running costs. —100 hours~~ (£5-8k opportunity cost). Some emotional investment.

What you've still gained: Complete AI-native fluency. A stunning More Air case study. End-to-end product shipping experience. Rieko's art digitised and preserved. An incorporated IP entity with trademarks. Knowledge of what doesn't work.

What you haven't lost: More Air (client work continues throughout). Your reputation (nobody judges a quiet product that didn't scale). Your creative partnership.

Total downside: £5-10k. A fraction of what most founders spend validating an idea. And you keep the skills, brand assets, case study, and IP regardless.

The Thing to Remember When You Hit a Wall

There will be a Wednesday morning around Week 5 or 6 when the code isn't working, the AI reflections sound generic, the social numbers are flat, and you'll wonder what the hell you're doing. You'll look at the client invoices and think "we should just do more of that."

When that happens, read this:

Rieko created a being who crosses galaxies to reveal the soul within all living things, from a tiny blue flower in a dark forest to a coral that has lived for centuries. She spent ten years on it. Ten years of drawing, writing, imagining, and believing that this universe mattered enough to keep building even when nobody was watching.

That's not a business plan. That's a calling. And the only thing worse than building something that doesn't scale is never building it at all.

The tools exist. The strategy is sound. The philosophy is real. The art is beautiful. The worst case is survivable. The best case is life-changing.

Build the thing.

When in doubt: Auwa does not fix. Auwa reveals.